CHAPTER 14

THE DREAM

Ever since I was a boy, I have had a recurring dream – the same dream over and over again, to a point where the exact sequence of events could not be more vivid or more clear in my mind.

It is the ICC Cricket World Cup final and I am fielding at cover. The batsman is left-handed and he drives, making a solid connection. I dive to my right, gather the ball at full stretch, spring to my feet, run towards the stumps and take off the bails. We all appeal. The umpire's finger is raised, and South Africa wins the World Cup.

Then, agitated and excited, I wake up …

The frustration and pain of successive World Cup disappointments linger for me, as they linger for millions of South Africans: in 1992, we were denied by the rain against England in Sydney, which left the scoreboard famously reading 'South Africa to win need 22 runs off 1 ball'; in 1996, we were one of the favourites, but were eliminated by Brian Lara's century in the quarterfinal in Karachi after Allan Donald had been left out.

In 1999, our family was watching together on television when South Africa played Australia in the semifinal in Birmingham, and we needed nine from the last over with one wicket standing. Lance Klusener drove the first two balls for boundaries, and we needed one to win from four balls. Allan Donald was almost run out backing up off the third ball. Next, Lance called for a quick single but Allan didn't hear him and was